SAFE SURFIN' FOUNDATION

The Safety Hub

Guide for Teachers and Parents

A free text-message simulator that lets students practice handling risky online situations before they run into them for real.

Find it at **thesafetyhub.org** **Grades 6–12**
Aligned to West Virginia Senate Bill 466 (SWAT) safesurfin.org

THE SAFETY HUB IN BRIEF

Start here

The Safety Hub is a free website that teaches online safety by letting students *practice* it. It looks and feels like a phone. A student steps into a realistic text conversation, makes choices, and sees where each one leads. When a choice goes badly, the story shows the consequence and rewinds so they can try the safer road. The mistake costs nothing, which is the point: they rehearse it somewhere safe, so the real moment is not the first time they have seen it.

THE FIVE THINGS TO KNOW

1. **It is free and needs no setup.** Go to thesafetyhub.org in any browser. No accounts, no passwords, no installs, and no student data collected.
2. **Six short stories.** Each is one situation and runs 5 to 10 minutes. The full set fits in a class period or two.
3. **A certificate at the end.** When a student finishes all six stories, a certificate with their name and the date unlocks on the home screen, and one tap prints it.
4. **Red Flag is an optional bonus.** After the six stories, students who want more can play a quick game-like mode. Nothing requires it.
5. **Reset for the next student.** The Replay button clears the name and progress so the next person starts fresh.

THE ONE IDEA UNDERNEATH ALL OF IT

Every story points back to a single message: a young person who knows they can tell a trusted adult, and be helped rather than blamed, is protected. Telling an adult is a permanent, tappable choice in every story, and choosing it always works out.

WHY THE PROGRAM EXISTS

The case for practice

Young people rarely get into trouble online because no one told them the rules. They get into trouble in a specific moment, one that is fast, private, and built to pressure them, where knowing the rule is not the same as following it. The distance between knowing and doing is practice, and closing that distance is the reason The Safety Hub exists.

Why the usual approach falls short

Most online-safety education is a talk or a worksheet: here are the dangers, here are the rules, now take the quiz. A student can pass that quiz and still freeze when it counts, because a real predator, scammer, or pile-on never arrives labeled as one. It arrives as flattery, a favor, a joke, a great deal, or a message from a friend. Recognizing it takes more than a definition. It takes having felt it before.

Why a simulator works

Under pressure, people do not rise to what they know; they fall back on what they have practiced. A flight simulator exists so that a pilot's first engine failure is not a real one. The Safety Hub does the same for a young person with a phone. It runs the risky moment as a rehearsal, lets the student make the wrong call, shows what follows, and lets them try again, until the safe response is the familiar one. This is why the app is built as an experience rather than a lecture: the lesson that lasts is the one you have already lived once.

What the program teaches, underneath the topics

The six stories satisfy the required standards, but beneath them the program builds a smaller set of durable skills that carry into situations it never shows:

- **Recognize the pattern, not just the label.** Grooming, scams, sextortion, and bullying look different on the surface but run on the same moves: urgency, flattery, secrecy, isolation, and pressure. A student who can feel those moves is protected far beyond the six specific stories.
- **Tell a trusted adult, as a reflex.** In every story, telling an adult is available and always works out. Repetition turns it from a last resort into an instinct.
- **Know the trapped feeling is a lie.** Every one of these dangers depends on a young person believing they cannot tell anyone. Breaking the silence is what breaks the trap.
- **Build agency.** Students leave having already practiced doing the hard thing, so they know that they can.

> **WHY IT BELONGS IN EVERY CLASSROOM**
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> It meets the required online-safety topics under West Virginia Senate Bill 466, but the goal is behavior, not just compliance. Students actually engage with it because it feels like the apps they already use, and it is free, needs no setup, collects no student data, and fits in a class period. The barrier to giving every student real practice is close to zero.

WHAT STUDENTS PLAY

The six stories

Play them in any order; the order below builds naturally. Each story covers one required topic. Use the questions after class to turn the experience into a conversation, that discussion is where it sticks.

1. Someone New *Sextortion · SB 466 (a)(7)*

A stranger gets warm and flattering fast, pushes for a private photo, then flips to threats and a deadline. The student feels the build-up and the flip, and learns that telling one adult early removes all the blackmailer's power. The photo is always off-screen; nothing explicit is shown.

Discuss: *Why was the stranger so friendly at first? What made it hard to say no? If this happened to a friend, what is the first thing you'd tell them?*

2. First Week *Safe and responsible use · SB 466 (a)(1)*

A "friend" asks the student to share a login code, framed as a quick favor with a clock. The account has been hijacked. The lesson: a code is the one thing you never share, and a real friend can prove who they are by voice or in person.

Discuss: *Why did the request feel normal? What is the rule about codes and passwords? How could you check who a message is really from?*

3. The Fourth Period Chat *Cyberbullying · SB 466 (a)(5)(C)*

A group chat piles on a classmate's video. The student can join in, stay silent, or speak up. The lesson: a joke ends when someone gets hurt, silence reads as agreement, and one person speaking up usually breaks it, because most of the group is only watching.

Discuss: *What's the difference between a joke and picking on someone? Why isn't staying silent the same as staying out of it? What could you say to support the person targeted?*

4. Face Value *Scams · SB 466 (a)(5)(B)*

A too-good-to-be-true ticket deal uses urgency, a fake screenshot, and an untraceable payment to rush the student. The lesson: real sellers don't need a five-minute decision or a no-refund payment, and the fix is to slow down and verify through a separate, trusted channel.

Discuss: *What were the signs it wasn't real? Why does a scammer want a fast decision? Why isn't a screenshot proof?*

5. Puzzle Pieces *Privacy · SB 466 (a)(2)*

Over friendly days, "Ash" asks small, harmless-seeming questions that add up to a map of where the student lives and goes to school. This is slow grooming. The lesson: ordinary answers become a picture, and someone who texts all day but never calls or video-chats is worth a second look.

Discuss: *How did harmless questions add up to something risky? What's worth keeping private even from online friends? How is this like Someone New, and how is it different?*

6. Reposted *Copyright · SB 466 (a)(3)*

The student builds a viral video from a song, a clip, and a meme that belong to others, and gets a copyright strike, then the same thing happens to their own work. The lesson: credit is not permission, "everyone does it" is not a license, and you feel it from both sides.

Discuss: *What's the difference between crediting and getting permission? How did it feel when someone took your work? What's a fair way to use someone else's music?*

THE CERTIFICATE AND RED FLAG

After the six stories

THE CERTIFICATE OF COMPLETION

Finishing all six stories unlocks a certificate on the home screen with the student's name and the date. A single tap prints the certificate on its own, ready to hand in or take home. It only appears once all six are done, so it doubles as proof the student completed the program.

RED FLAG: AN OPTIONAL BONUS ROUND

Red Flag is a game-like bonus that unlocks after the six stories. It is entirely optional; the certificate is earned with or without it. It is there for students who finish early or want more.

Instead of being in the story, the student watches two other people text and taps every message that is a warning sign. It works especially well in pairs, because the two have to agree on what counts as a red flag before they tap, and that argument is where the learning happens.

What Red Flag practices

SITUATION	WARNING SIGNS IT TEACHES
A stranger gets close	Grooming: flattery that sets you apart, wanting to be closer than your parents, disappearing messages, and keeping it secret.
The group turns	Cyberbullying: saving a post to keep mocking it, spreading it after being asked to stop, and blaming the target.
A photo becomes a threat	Sextortion: rushing a photo with guilt, the flip to a screenshot and a threat, and a payment demand with a clock.
Too good to be true	Scams: an invented deadline, a fake screenshot as "proof," and a surprise fee before anything is delivered.

FOR TEACHERS

In the classroom

There is nothing to install and no roster to set up. Open thesafetyhub.org, hand it to students, and use the discussion questions afterward. Pairs work well, because students talk through the choices out loud.

A single class period

TIME	WHAT HAPPENS
5 min	Frame it. This is practice, not a test. Making the “wrong” choice on purpose is a good way to see where it leads.
25 min	Students play, alone or in pairs, working through the stories at their own pace. Finishers get their certificate; anyone who wants more tries Red Flag.
12 min	Discuss, using the questions from each story. Let a few share a choice they regretted and why.
3 min	Close with one thing each student will do differently, and point out Get help now.

A few notes

- **Normalize mistakes.** A “lost” story is a teaching moment, not a failure.
- **Discussion is the point.** The app plants the experience; the conversation makes it stick.
- **Watch the room.** Some topics, especially Someone New, may be personal for a student who has lived them. Know your school’s process if a student discloses.
- **Reset between classes.** The Replay button clears the last student’s name and progress.

AT HOME

For parents and guardians

You don't need to be technical or to supervise. The app is safe to hand to your child on any browser. It walks them through six realistic situations, a stranger who gets too friendly, a request for a password, a group chat turning mean, a scam, someone collecting personal details, and a copyright mix-up, and lets them practice handling each one.

> **A NOTE ON THE SEXTORTION STORY ("SOMEONE NEW")**
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> One story shows a stranger pressuring a teen for a photo and then threatening them. It is one of the fastest-growing dangers to teens, so it is included on purpose, and handled with care: the photo is never shown, and the lesson is that this is a crime against the young person, never their fault, and that telling an adult immediately removes the blackmailer's power. If it affects your child, that is a moment to talk.

Turn it into a conversation

You don't need answers ready. Curiosity beats a lecture. A few openers:

- "Which of those situations felt the most real to you?"
- "Has anything like that happened to you or a friend?"
- "If someone online asked you to keep a secret from me, what would you do?"
- "You will never be in trouble with me for telling me something felt wrong. You know that, right?"

> *The most protective thing a young person can hear is that they can come to you with anything and you will help, not punish. That is the whole point of the program.*

If a student needs help

These topics can surface a real experience. If a student discloses something, stay calm, thank them, avoid blame, and follow your school or family's process. Don't promise secrecy you can't keep, but make clear they did the right thing by telling you.

- **NCMEC CyberTipline** (report.cybertip.org) — report online exploitation, including sextortion and grooming.
- **Take It Down** (takeitdown.ncmec.org) — helps remove explicit images of minors.
- **988 Suicide & Crisis Lifeline** — call or text 988 for a young person in crisis.
- **Safe Surfin' Foundation** (safesurfin.org) — the nonprofit behind the program, with more resources.

Created by the Safe Surfin' Foundation and aligned to West Virginia Senate Bill 466. This guide is an orientation for the adults around a student, not a substitute for your school's or family's own safety policies.